Theatre Instruments: Classification & Care

Study notes — Maintenance of Perioperative Theatre Instruments unit. General instrument categories and basic care principles.

Broad instrument categories

- Cutting/dissecting — scalpels, scissors, osteotomes
- Grasping/holding — tissue forceps, Allis, Babcock clamps
- Clamping/occluding — artery forceps, bulldog clamps
- Retracting — Langenbeck, self-retaining retractors
- Suturing/stapling — needle holders, staplers
- Viewing — endoscopes, laryngoscopes

Basic care principles

- Pre-clean instruments at point of use to prevent debris drying on
- Handle delicate/sharp instruments separately to avoid damage
- Check joints, jaws, and tips for wear or misalignment before use
- Follow the manufacturer's decontamination instructions for each instrument type

Instrument count

- Counted at the start and end of every procedure per local policy
- Discrepancies reported and resolved before the patient leaves theatre

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